



SELECTION, TAPPING, LUNCHEONS, INITIATION



THE SELECTION PROCESS

Have you ever ridden the Seaboard Coast Line? At 2:00 in the morning, you squirm and shift in your seat in the coach trying to sleep. Outside, cars are added and removed in the dark, nightmare railroad yards of Jacksonville. When, at last it is 3:15 a.m., and the train is rocking and bumping and rattling evenly beneath you again, you roll your jacket up under your head and dream.

The sun comes up somewhere about 80 miles north of Palm Beach and you dig through your bag to find the toothpaste. Then, refreshed, you walk back to the dining car for eggs and hashbrowns and cantaloupe on heavy pewter plates. Outside your window, the cabbage palms and grazing cattle and morning mists slip away. What has all this got to do with Iron Arrow?

Iron Arrow selection meetings used to be like that. At 2:00 in the morning, you would squirm and shift in your seat as names were added and removed and the glare from the lights would keep you awake. When, at last, it was 3:15 a.m. and the tribe was rocking and rattling along evenly again for another semester, you could wrap your jacket up and rest. The breakfast afterward was usually taken at Holsum's on U.S. 1 just south of the UM.

The nighttime selection was a holdover from the times when the school





and the tribe were smaller and selections could be easily handled in the evening. By selecting only one night or so before tapping, we maintained maximum secrecy.

Like the heyday of the railroads, however, that unforgettable system is a thing of the past. If it were my choice, I would welcome back the railroads, for they have a charm to cherish. But the nighttime selection meeting can molder in its grave. Everybody got so tired; it was an event terrible to experience, though pleasant to remember.¹²⁵

New members are chosen twice a year: just before Homecoming in the fall and just before Carni Gras in the spring. Hidden here from all but its members is the vigorous, relentless tradition that perpetuates the highest honor attained at the University.

Each nominee is judged individually against the criteria of membership: leadership, character, scholarship, service, and love of alma mater. Qualities such as humility are also considered. Students must have a 2.0 cumulative average, while faculty and staff must have been associated with the University for at least five years, usually more. Alumni are considered only on the basis of their achievements after graduation. These then are the broad outlines within which the selection process takes place.

The selection process is in every sense an adversarial proceeding, in the best tradition of American jurisprudence. The adversaries change from moment to moment and from nominee to nominee; rising spontaneously and fading just as quickly when argument is concluded. Doctors of chemistry and engineering and music attend, as do university presidents and vice presidents. Occasionally, a student body president will join in discussion with All-American athletes, Carni Gras chairmen, or Homecoming coordinators. A member of the Board of Trustees may challenge the arguments of a famous alumnus. All are members of Iron Arrow. All at one time or another have listened to and spoken of the qualities of the candidates under consideration.

In this environment, devils' advocates test each candidate's qualifications with probing questions. The truly qualified candidates easily survive the acid tests. Because these proceedings are honest and deliberative, they remain within the confidence of tribal members. When all the members assembled are in agreement, there is no doubt that the nominees selected are worthy of Miami's highest honor.

To appreciate the success of this selection process, consider the following, from *The Miami Hurricane* of January 16, 1953:

"Students tapped were Fritz Richter, president of the Student Asso-

¹²⁵ Daytime selection meetings were inaugurated by Rhea Warren on Saturday, October 23, 1971.





ciation and Omicron Delta Kappa member; Wayne Whisler, treasurer of the S.A. and member of ODK; and George Buchman, ODK and editor of the three Law School publications.”

“Iron Arrow also chose George Vickery, editor of *The Hurricane*, ODK member and president of SDX; Ray Fisher, ODK, editor emeritus of *Tempo* and *Ibis* chief photographer. Representing sports were Eddie Segall, varsity boxer, cheerleader, and president of the M-Club; and Frank Smith, 1952 varsity football player.”

Early in the morning, while the sky is still pale with night and the dew still wet on the grass, Iron Arrows begin to congregate at the tapping mound. There, on a small knoll beneath a shady ficus tree is the Iron Arrow monument.





TAPPING

A few sticks of wood are placed in the firebowl, and soon the smell of smoke begins to drift across the campus. It is tapping day.

The large kettle drum is brought to the mound and placed beside the firebowl. Seminole jackets are unloaded from someone's automobile and draped on the moldy stone wall and on the drum. The Chief dons his breastplates and checks to make sure that greasepaint is available. The Medicine Man arrives with the large orange drum that will be used in the tapping lines. The Son of Chief reviews his list of tappees and their whereabouts throughout the morning.

Now the advisor will take his pipe from his mouth and give the signal to begin. The kettle drum begins to throb; BOOM boom boom boom. BOOM boom boom boom. The rhythm is slow and the easy. Greetings are exchanged with late arrivals and three members leave to order breakfast in the Ibis Cafeteria. By 7:30 a.m., 20 members are present; each wearing his Seminole jacket; each jacket different from the other in colors and in patterns.

At 8:00 a.m., the Son of Chief announces the name of the first tappee. One of the members picks up the Arrow and holds it, parallel to the ground a few inches in front of his chest. A line forms behind him. First behind him are two members who know the man to be tapped. Next is the drummer, who drapes the large orange drum over his shoulder and begins to copy the rhythm of the large kettle drum beside the fire. The other members fall in behind him, their arms crossed upon their chests. Silence is admonished and the line files off across the campus, in search of the tradition's future.

Unsuspecting, probably sluggish from the early hour, the tappee sits in his early morning class, converting his professor's expertise into ciphers of ink on paper. Far away is the echo of a kettle drum, and just outside the window a tradewind stirs the palm fronds. A bird, light-headed with the morning, chortles to himself. Outside the room a drumbeat is heard approaching; growing louder and louder until suddenly, it is in the room and all lecturing has ceased as the colored jackets and the solemn, primitive rhythm break the morning's spell.

The man with the Arrow moves toward the back of the room and suddenly thrusts the iron relic into the air. Simultaneously, the drum beat breaks into a throbbing frenzy. With a swift downward plunge, the fists clutching the Arrow have struck the new member with a jolt upon the shoulder blades; thereby, protecting bone from iron. BOOM. The frenzied beat comes to a halt. Two Iron Arrows seize the tappee by either arm and pull him from his chair as the drum immediately resumes the primitive rhythm by which it had arrived. The man with the Arrow holds it again before his chest and leaves the room. Behind him is the new tappee, still caught tightly in the grasp of his captors, his books





and papers left in disarray behind him. Then follows the drummer and the rest of the Iron Arrows. Not a single word has been spoken.

As the tapping line nears the tapping mound, the two drummers synchronize their time and the tappee is brought to stand before the Chief. Behind the tappee, the tapping line forms a silent semi-circle facing the mound as the Arrow is transferred to the Chief. The Chief thrusts the Arrow high into the air, and again the drums break into a rapid, frenzied beat. Suddenly, the Arrow is plunged into the ground at the tappee's feet and both drums fall silent. The Chief then takes greasepaint from the Son of Chief and places two marks on the tappee's forehead: one green and one orange. Then the Chief says: "Congratulations. You have been tapped into Iron Arrow, the highest honor attained by men at the University of Miami. You are required by tribal law to wear the ceremonial jacket and ceremonial colors of the tribe and to appear before a gathering of the tribe at 1:00 p.m., at the Holiday Inn of Coral Gables." The kettle drum then resumes its beat, congratulations are offered, the tappee is given a jacket to wear, and pictures are taken. The future has begun.

Atmosphere: Professional, cordial, tasteful, appropriate, relaxed. They always begin with reunions and handshakes, with cocktails and the murmur of conversation, talk of business and sports. It seems that every law firm and hospital in Miami is represented by a member in attendance.

Soon the tables begin to fill. The lights grow dim and a slow rhythmic boom silences the room; the new tappees file in. The drum rolls with a frenzy, then with a final boom falls silent. An invocation is offered by Dr. Ivan Hoy,





TAPPING LUNCHEONS

chairman of the Department of Religion. Or Father Henry Minich will rise to offer an Indian prayer, filled with the haunting spirituality of cultures and times long past.

On November 6, 1975, Minich intoned an ancient Tewa prayer:

Oh, our Mother the earth.
Oh, our Father the sky.
Your children are we, and with tired backs
We bring you the gifts that you love.
Then weave for us a garment of brightness;

May the warp be the white light of morning,
May the weft be the red light of evening,
May the fringes be the falling rain,
May the border be the standing rainbow.
Then weave for us a garment of brightness
That we may walk fittingly where birds sing,
That we may walk fittingly where grass is green,
Oh, our mother the earth.
Oh, our father the sky.

Then these moments are quickly over and the lights return as the tables fill with salads and coffee and entree.

In the manner of such gatherings, the business begins as dessert is served. It begins with humor, and with luck, continues that way. The new tappees are introduced, and the activities for which they were chosen are described. Dr. Stanford, members of “the founding nine,” officers and other dignitaries are introduced. Typically, Iron Arrow’s guest speaker is a politician, a scholar, or an athletic director, not necessarily in that order of frequency.

At the memorable luncheon of November 7, 1974, Iron Arrow’s special guest was Howard Osceola, whose village makes the jackets worn by members of the tribe. The following remarks were delivered in honoring his presence at the luncheon:

As you entered this room you saw prominently displayed a jacket along with a beaded sash and a turban. The jacket is called a Medicine Man’s jacket. These garments are exact replicas of those worn by Seminole braves during the Seminole Indian wars. Eventually, other forms of dress were adopted. The last tribal leader to retain this garb was the Medicine Man, thus the





term Medicine Man's jacket.

Today we acknowledge the gift of these valuable items to the tribe by Howard Osceola. Howard Osceola is a Mikasuki Indian. He does not live on any reservation and he does not accept federal monies. I say this because this is a source of great pride with him.

In recognition of his great friendship and support over the years we would like to present him with this framed portrait of his grandparents.¹¹⁴

The value of the gift Howard Osceola had just accorded Iron Arrow can be appreciated only in the recognition that the garments represent an archaic style; exceedingly rare because they are seldom made anymore. The three-foot photograph of Howard's grandparents, framed by five-inch-wide cypress planks, awakens the ghosts of the society's founding in 1926, for Howard's grandfather was none other than Willie Willie, the chauffeur for Mrs. McAllister. Today the photograph hangs in Howard's small, cluttered office on the Tamiami Trail at the edge of the everglades.

Before any luncheon can be closed, two traditions must be observed. The organization was charged by Dr. Ashe with the responsibility of protecting



¹¹⁴ Remarks of Rhea Warren, November 7, 1974.





the welfare of the University of Miami and its traditions. In adherence to that charge, twice each year Iron Arrow conducts a “24-hour drum vigil” symbolizing that responsibility in ritual. Despite the serious symbolism of the ritual, it is with amusement that members await the news of which tappees are assigned as sentries to the late and lonely hours. With a wry smile, the Medicine Man points out that the hours assigned are chosen in a “more or less” random procedure.

In the second tradition, it is the tappees’ turn to smile. For each luncheon is closed with an “asi toast” in which members only participate. The asi is the “black drink” for which Osceola was named in the Indian Wars. The implications of this toast can be appreciated in the realization that the Seminole recipe consists mainly of the leaves of the Florida tree, *Ilex vomitoria*, the yaupon.¹¹⁵ From the latter the early settlers enjoyed a harmless, mild brew, while the ‘black drink’ of Indian ceremonies was very strong, from prolonged boiling, and was both emetic and purgative, especially when taken in quantity.”¹¹⁶

An Iron Arrow tappee may not become a member of the tribe until he has undergone the tribe’s semi-annual initiation ceremonies held in the Everglades. The all-night ritual remains secret to all but members and a small handful of Seminoles, but certain descriptions can be made. Following the tapping ceremonies at the Iron Arrow mound, the tappee is given a letter by the Medicine Man congratulating him on his selection. The letter indicates, however, that membership is contingent upon participation in the initiation ceremonies. He is instructed as to a time and place at which he is to appear and certain items which he is to bring with him; some of which are precautionary in nature. These items include: a can of insect repellant, four flashlights with fresh batteries, a change of clothing, a typewritten history of the tribes which have inhabited the Florida Everglades, a compass and map of South Florida, and one roll of one-inch adhesive tape.

¹¹⁵ Morton, Julia F., *Wild Plants for Survival in South Florida*, Trend House, Tampa, Florida.

¹¹⁶ Ibid.





THE INITIATION



How can we describe an Iron Arrow initiation for you without describing it? If we could make this page come alive with the odor of insect repellent, we would. This odor is as much a part of Iron Arrow as the jackets and the drum. In an initiation, the senses are choked by it. There is also the musty smell of decaying vegetation. Interwoven with these are the wet smell of water and the smoke of burning wood and the syrupy fragrance of pollen.

Of course, the pitch black of the nighttime wilderness is part of the IA initiation. There are shadows from fires and pinpoints of light that are stars; thousands more than can be seen from the city. We have seen falling stars sometimes on these nights. And there is a fear and superstition so real it can be felt, arising in part from the darkness and in part from the isolation of the wilderness. The sounds of the ceremonies are sounds of the Florida wilderness, and the Florida past. There is the hum of mosquitoes around one's head and, in the stillness, the wind through the trees and sawgrass. There are nighttime sounds of crickets and birds and katydids, broken by an occasional splash of water or a dull, slow throbbing of tribal drums. And sometimes there is the moaning bellow of hal-pattah, the alligator. And there is also the sound of the spoken word.

Initiations are times when one stumbles in the dark into the web of





hjophynie, the spider. They are times that biologists and historians never forget. Anthropologists and theologians come away as from a second genesis of the spirit. All that is primitive and ancient is wrapped into the cover of night with all that can ever be. While he is seated on the earth and the grasses, the leader feels his accomplishments dwindle to insignificance before the accomplishments of the Greatest Leader. Images and odors merge with the dull beat of drums older than any measure of time. With each slow breath, emotion hangs suspended in the blackness as thick and oppressive as the humidity. These are the magic packets in the powerful yaholi bundles of the Iron Arrow.





THE FEMINIST CHALLENGE

For months each year, South Florida lies oppressed beneath the summer humidity and heat. The tropical seas silently spawn storm after storm, sending one after another shuffling toward landfalls around the Caribbean and the Gulf of Mexico.

Something about the political climate in the United States began to change in the early '60s, and the social milieu began to spawn its storms too. I have already mentioned two of these which buffeted the University and the tough old tribal walls, the storms of political dissent and a culture sustained by drugs. Now still another storm was spawned, and began its course toward Iron Arrow on November 30, 1972.

The Miami News on that date charted the storm's first position: "Women's Lib Goes On Warpath Against UM Iron Arrow Society." The opening paragraph indicated a tropical storm with strong gusts near the center. "Women's lib is on the warpath against Iron Arrow, the tom-tom beating honorary society at the University of Miami. And a determined band of students hopes to lift its scalp tonight."

During the winter, the storm intensified to hurricane strength and on May 10, 1973, made landfall, striking the tribe with full force. The Region IV office of the Department of Health, Education and Welfare in Atlanta, Georgia, addressed the following letter to Dr. Henry King Stanford, President of the University (partial quote only):

"Dear Dr. Stanford:

We have received a complaint alleging that the Iron Arrow Society at the University of Miami discriminates against and is demeaning to a minority class specifically protected by Title VI of the Civil Rights Act of 1964, namely, Indians, and that said Society further discriminates against a class of persons protected by Title IX of the Education Amendments of 1972 of the Higher Education Act, namely, females."¹¹⁷

The letter went on to request extensive information about Iron Arrow, which was provided by John Leatherwood on June 1, 1973, on behalf of the IA advisory board.

The hurricanes of the tropics are characterized by a dead calm in the storm center, called "the eye." On opposite sides of this center, the winds roar in opposite directions. As Iron Arrow battened down to weather the blow, the first complaint to be challenged was that alleging our traditions to be demean-

¹¹⁷ United States Department of Health, Education, and Welfare, letter from Region IV Office to Dr. Henry King Stanford, May 10, 1973.





ing and discriminatory to Indians as a class. Leatherwood pointed out that he himself bore Indian lineage through his paternal great-grandmother who was a full-blooded Oklahoma Cherokee. Rhea Warren indicated similar Cherokee heritage originating in Tennessee. Tony Tommie's role in the founding of the organization as the "Supreme Counselor" of Iron Arrow was cited.

Marie Cypress Osceola, a majorette at the University, wrote a letter taking exception to charges that the tribe's use of Indian jackets was "undignified." "Do you also consider the Indian men and women uncivilized if they wear their traditional clothes? How can it be a disregard to our dignity when our works are considered masterpieces in clothing?"¹¹⁸

The evidence was just beginning. On June 22, 1973, Iron Arrow provided the following information to Ted Nichols of Dr. Stanford's office, who was in frequent phone communication with HEW: "For many years, the Indians of the Village of William McKinley Osceola have sewn the traditional patchwork jackets for members of our Society. Upon surveying this village, we found total accord with Ms. Osceola's position, and were informed by its leader, Howard Osceola, that his people take great pride in their relationship with Iron Arrow; he wished his name to be included in any statement that the Society might prepare."¹¹⁹ A copy of the Society's ritual and constitution were forwarded to the HEW investigators, and Chief John Leatherwood summed up the tribe's response as follows:

"Throughout its almost half-century at the University of Miami, Iron Arrow has dedicated itself to two purposes: honoring through membership those individuals who rendered a truly notable service to the institution; keeping the University community mindful of the presence and heritage of the Seminole and Mikasuki Tribes of South Florida. Both of these have been and continue to be carried out with dedication and excellence."¹²⁰

Other evidence could have been presented to cement the case, if it had been known at the time. The fact that John McGuire, one of the founding nine, bears fully one-half Indian blood from his Wasach mother was not known. It also had been forgotten that George "Hotonka" LaMere (IA 1927-28) was a full-blooded Winnebago Indian. The full extent of Tony Tommie's involvement had been lost for years and years: Iron Arrow had been founded as an actual "clan" of the Seminole Nation.

¹¹⁸ Osceola, Marie Cypress, May 16, 1973.

¹¹⁹ Leatherwood, John E., on behalf of Iron Arrow, To Nichols, Ted, June 22, 1973.

¹²⁰ Leatherwood, John E., letter to HEW investigators, June 1, 1973.





Suddenly, on October 25, 1973, the winds stopped howling. The Indian issue had been resolved. The letter read in part as follows:

“Dear Dr. Stanford:

We have reached a conclusion on the aspect of the complaint which alleges that the Iron Arrow Society’s utilization of Indian attire is demeaning and degrading to Indians in general. In our consideration of this charge we have looked at the issues in terms of the broader effect of the Iron Arrow Society’s use of Indian nomenclature, paraphernalia, ceremonial customs, etc., as well as the wearing of Indian dress.

Our investigating has included an analysis of the society’s constitution and ritual, as well as, contacts with Indian persons knowledgeable about Seminole and Mikasuki tribal customs and Iron Arrow itself.

We do not find evidence to support a claim that the society’s use of Indian ritual and appurtenances is, per se, demeaning of either Seminole and Mikasuki Indians or of Indians in general. Indeed, our investigation shows that qualities of life and philosophy portrayed in the society’s ritual show Indians in what must be considered a positive or favorable light. Our investigation showed, furthermore, that there is no policy of exclusion of Indians from Iron Arrow, that certain now active members have Indian ancestry and that a local Mikasuki Chief was at one time a member.

The present, inclusion of black members in this the society would belie any claim that it is racially exclusive in membership, while the present absence of any members who are full-blooded Indians must be seen as a corollary of the relative scarcity of such persons as members of the University community.”¹²¹

Iron Arrow inspected its tradition and found it had withstood the first squalls of the storm solidly.

The storm center lull was not to remain long. From the Friday, February 15, 1974, student paper: “Iron Arrow’s reputation has been one of the foremost in the Miami area, but its esteem could reach even higher peaks if its members would ‘sink so low’ as to allow female membership.” Meantime, the silence from HEW was considered ominous by some, promising by others. The howling winds of March 24, 1974, brought word from Gainesville that the University

¹²¹ United States Department of Health, Education, and Welfare, letter from Region IV Office to Dr. Henry King Stanford, October 25, 1973.





of Florida's Blue Key leadership society had been ordered to admit women by the Florida Board of Education. The president of Blue Key at that time was Jim Reinman of Melbourne. He was quoted in the Miami Herald, saying, "In the past, people felt we had the right to restrict membership, and we were under no compulsion to change."¹²² On November 5, 1974, UM's chapter of Omicron Delta Kappa (ODK), national fraternity for scholarship and leadership, tapped its first female member, Alumni Relations Director Jenny Coburn. The national female equivalent of ODK, however, continued its policy of excluding males from membership. Thus Mortar Board which had once been UM's Nu Kappa Tau maintained its traditional integrity in the face of the storm. Still there was no word from Washington. Dean Frederick Lewis of the Law School was guest speaker at the spring tapping luncheon of 1974, and made the observation that should the government order Iron Arrow to accept women for membership, "it would not be the first time in history that an Indian tribe was put asunder from Washington."

Wednesday, June 4, 1975, brought the Miami Herald headlines, "Sex Discrimination Banned in Schools." HEW had established its policies regarding athletics, scholarships, employment, and many other activities. "While college social fraternities and sororities are exempt, groups such as business and professional fraternities and sororities and honor societies may not discriminate by sex."¹²³ Whether 50 years of Iron Arrow tradition would weather the storm without major structural damage was thrown into doubt.



¹²² The Miami Herald, March 24, 1975.

¹²³ The Miami Herald, June 4, 1975.





BITS AND PIECES

The first Iron Arrow tapping seen live on television occurred February 21, 1973. On that evening's Ralph Renick Report, WTVJ's Sports Director, Bob Halloran, was tapped during the broadcast of the 6:00 p.m. news. An audience of thousands watched as Chief Rhea Warren, Chuck Foreman, Ray Bellamy, and Burgess Owens tapped the sportscaster while longtime Iron Arrow member Ralph Renick looked on.

Another Iron Arrow member was making history in quite another way. Former student-body President Jim Fleming is famous to thousands at the University of Miami for his ability to manipulate a crowd as UM head cheerleader. Most observers felt Fleming had reached his peak when he threw his shoulder out of joint one night while leading a cheer before a thunderous Orange Bowl crowd. Others thought it might have been the time he and the Band of the Hour struck up a mock funeral dirge for Notre Dame's Ara Parseghian in 1967: "Cheer up, Ara, the worst is yet to come." But alumnus Fleming topped both occasions when Miami police arrested him on the Orange Bowl sidelines in 1973 for "inciting a riot." His crime? Leading the Orange Bowl crowd in the famous UM Yamma-Yamma cheer. Says Fleming, "They even read me my 'rights.'"

One of the most memorable of the society's social events was a tribal celebration at the home of Dr. Henry Field in Coconut Grove on May 20, 1973. The home of the famous archaeologist, explorer and anthropologist is located on Main Highway in the heart of Miami's historical bayfront community. Born into a prominent Chicago family, famous as the founders of a department store chain and the Chicago Sun, Field during his lifetime has met secretly with Lawrence of Arabia and explored the forbidden burial chambers of Egypt's 3,400-year-old tomb of King Tut.¹²⁴

Before his death in 1973, Academy Award nominee and Iron Arrow member Michael Dunn starred in the film "Ship of Fools." Returning for Homecoming, 1967, the celebrated UM alumnus was tapped during half-time ceremonies in the Orange Bowl stadium by Chief Tom Spencer.



¹²⁴ Tropic Magazine, The Miami Herald, 1975.

